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## Joby Aviation and defense contractor L3Harris to test autonomous hybrid aircraft

Kirsten Korosec — 5:00 AM PDT · August 1, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: JOBY AVIATION

Joby Aviation is often cast as a developer of commercial electric air taxis, but the publicly traded company has also pursued a separate track to market through a long-standing relationship with the U.S. Department of Defense. Now, its years of research and development with the Department of Defense may be paying off.

The company on Thursday said it had signed an agreement with defense contractor L3Harris Technologies to “explore opportunities” to develop a new aircraft class — specifically, a gas-turbine hybrid vertical take-off and landing aircraft that can fly autonomously — for defense applications.

The gas-turbine hybrid VTOL will be based on Joby’s current S4 aircraft platform. The company has focused on developing the S4 with an all-electric powertrain, but it last year demonstrated under government contract a [hydrogen-electric hybrid version](#) that flew 521 miles — more than two times farther than its battery electric prototype.

The agreement with L3Harris is exploratory, but the hope is that upcoming flight tests and operational demonstrations will lead to a military contract with the DoD. Joby said flight testing will start this fall, and operational demonstrations are expected in 2026.

Joby has spent years developing and seeking Type 1 certification from the Federal Aviation Administration for its all-electric vertical take-off and landing aircraft, which will be used to shuttle passengers short distances in urban areas.

It’s also worked with the DoD at the development stage for nearly a decade. Through that relationship, Joby homed in on what it would take to get to the “finish line” with the DoD, Joby executive chairman Paul Sciarra told TechCrunch.

“One was that range was especially important,” he said. “We knew we had to make that shift.”



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Sciarra added it was also important to demonstrate the so-called “missionization of its platform” — how its aircraft could be combined with the right sensors, autonomy, communications and payload to provide a clear use case for the DoD.

“We have two choices: either build a bunch of this stuff ourselves, or find an incredible partner that already has a deep understanding of those use cases and a ton of proven technology,” he said.

That’s where L3Harris comes in.

Jon Rambeau, president of Integrated Mission Systems at L3Harris, said the new vertical lift technology will enable long-range, crewed-uncrewed teaming for a range of missions. In this case, the gas-turbine hybrid VTOL aircraft could be used for low-altitude support missions, which could include contested logistics, electronic warfare, and counter unmanned aircraft systems, or C-UAS, Sciarra said.

Topics: [defense tech](#) [Government & Policy](#) [Joby Aviation](#) [L3Harris](#)

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**Kirsten Korosec**

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Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous vehicles to urban air mobility and in-car tech for more...

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# Tesla shuts down Dojo, the AI training supercomputer that Musk said would be key to full self-driving

Rebecca Bellan — 3:19 PM PDT · August 7, 2025

Tesla is breaking up the team behind its [Dojo supercomputer](#), ending the automaker's play at developing in-house chips for driverless technology, according to [Bloomberg](#).

Dojo's lead, Peter Bannon, is leaving the company, and the remaining team members will be reassigned to other data center and compute projects within Tesla, per Bloomberg's reporting, which cited anonymous sources.

The disbanding of Tesla's Dojo efforts follows the departure of around 20 workers, who left the automaker to start their own [AI company called DensityAI](#). The new startup is reportedly coming out of stealth soon and is building chips, hardware, and software that will power data centers for AI that are used in robotics, by AI agents, and in automotive applications. DensityAI was founded by former Dojo head [Ganesh Venkataramanan](#) and ex-Tesla employees Bill Chang and Ben Floering.

It also comes at a crucial time for Tesla.

[CEO Elon Musk has pushed](#) to get shareholders to view Tesla as an AI and robotics company, despite a limited robotaxi launch in Austin this past June that featured Model Y vehicles with a human in the front passenger seat and resulted in a number of reported incidents of the vehicles exhibiting problematic driving behavior.

Tesla's decision to shut down Dojo, which Musk has been talking about since 2019, is a major shift in strategy. Musk has said that Dojo would be the cornerstone of Tesla's AI ambitions and its goal to reach full self-driving due to its ability to "process truly vast amounts of video data." He

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talked about Dojo, albeit briefly, as recently as the company’s second-quarter earnings call.

In 2023, Morgan Stanley predicted Dojo could add \$500 billion to the company’s market value by unlocking new revenue streams in the form of robotaxis and software services. Just last year, Musk noted that Tesla’s AI team would “[double down](#)” on Dojo in the lead-up to [Tesla’s robotaxi reveal](#), which happened in October.

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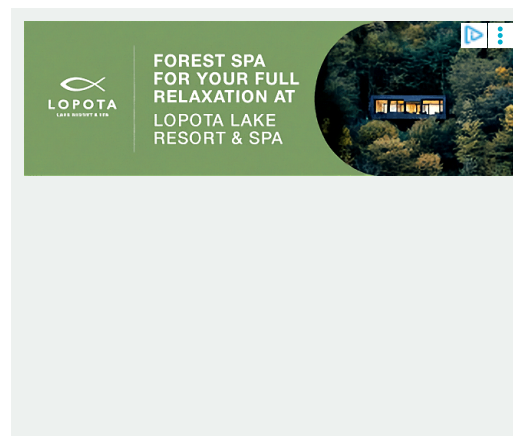


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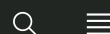
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Samsung for chip manufacturing. Tesla last month signed a [\\$10.5 billion deal with Samsung](#) to make its AI6 inference chips, a chip design that promises to scale from powering FSD and Tesla’s Optimus humanoid robots all the way to high-performance AI training in data centers.

During Tesla’s second-quarter earnings call, Musk hinted at potential redundancies.

“Thinking about Dojo 3 and the AI6 inference chip, it seems like intuitively, we want to try to find convergence there, where it’s basically the same chip,” Musk said.

The news comes as [Tesla’s board offers Musk a \\$29 billion pay package](#) to keep him at Tesla and help push the company’s AI efforts forward,

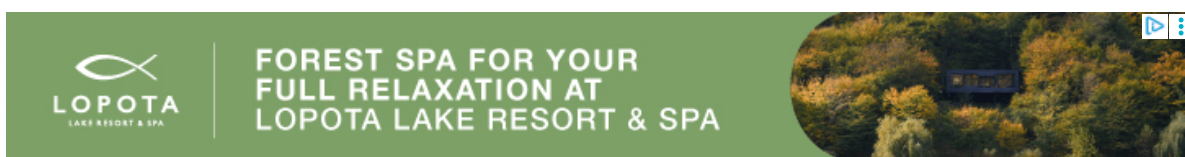
rather than getting too sidetracked by his other companies, including the more pure-play AI startup xAI.

TechCrunch has reached out to Tesla for more information.

*Have a sensitive tip or confidential documents? We're reporting on the inner workings of the AI industry — from the companies shaping its future to the people impacted by their decisions. Reach out to Rebecca Bellan at [rebecca.bellan@techcrunch.com](mailto:rebecca.bellan@techcrunch.com) and Maxwell Zeff at [maxwell.zeff@techcrunch.com](mailto:maxwell.zeff@techcrunch.com). For secure communication, you can contact us via Signal at [@rebeccabellan.491](https://www.signal.me) and [@mzeff.88](https://www.signal.me).*

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**Rebecca Bellan**

Senior Reporter | [X](#) [🦋](#)

Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch where she covers the business, policy, and emerging trends shaping artificial intelligence. Her work has also...

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# Rocket Lab eyes big defense opportunities with new acquisition





Rocket Lab is signaling to investors, yet again, that it's more than “just” a rocket company.

Rocket Lab's second-quarter results, which were posted Thursday, show revenues continue to be driven by its space systems business rather than launch. The results also highlight the company's acquisition strategy and how its purchase of a new optical payloads company will make it more competitive for lucrative government contracts.

The company's space systems brought in \$97.9 million of the \$144.5 million in total revenues for the second quarter. Rocket Labs' total revenue, its highest quarterly revenue in the company's history, jumped 36% from a year ago. The company's net loss widened to \$66.4 million.

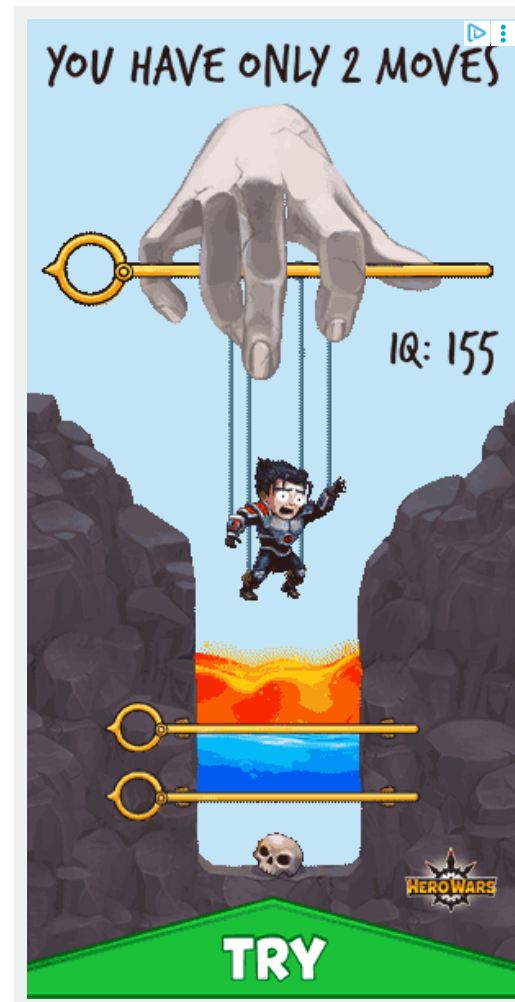
IMAGE CREDITS: [ROCKET LAB](#)

Rocket Lab founder and CEO Peter Beck highlighted the “busy quarter of M&A activity” as the company gets close to closing its deal to buy [Geost](#), a company that builds optical payloads. Through that acquisition, which will close at \$275 million in cash and equity, Rocket Lab is opening a new business unit called Optical Systems to scale electro-optical and infrared sensor manufacturing.

Those sensors are used in missile warning, tracking, and space domain awareness. The acquisition is also one part of a larger play from Rocket Lab — spelled out quite explicitly in the company's earnings presentation — to bid for multibillion-dollar [DOD initiatives like Golden Dome](#).

Rocket Lab has already won some major defense contracts, including a \$515 million, 18-satellite build contract to support the Space Development Agency's constellation of missile-tracking satellites. The company has moved into production on those satellites, following confirmation that they meet the DOD's mission requirements, Rocket Lab said.

Down on Earth, Rocket Lab says it's progressing well toward the first launch of its larger Neutron rocket. The rocket's launch complex in Virginia is expected to be complete in the third quarter of this year, with [hardware en route](#) and the new rocket engine, called Archimedes, undergoing multiple tests per day.



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Rocket Lab eyes big defense opportunities with new acquisition

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The company is staying vague about the exact launch date, saying only in the presentation that it is pushing an “all-out effort to get Neutron to the launch pad before the end of 2025.”

Rocket Lab ended the quarter with \$564 million in cash and cash equivalents and estimates revenues will hit between \$145 to \$155 million next quarter.

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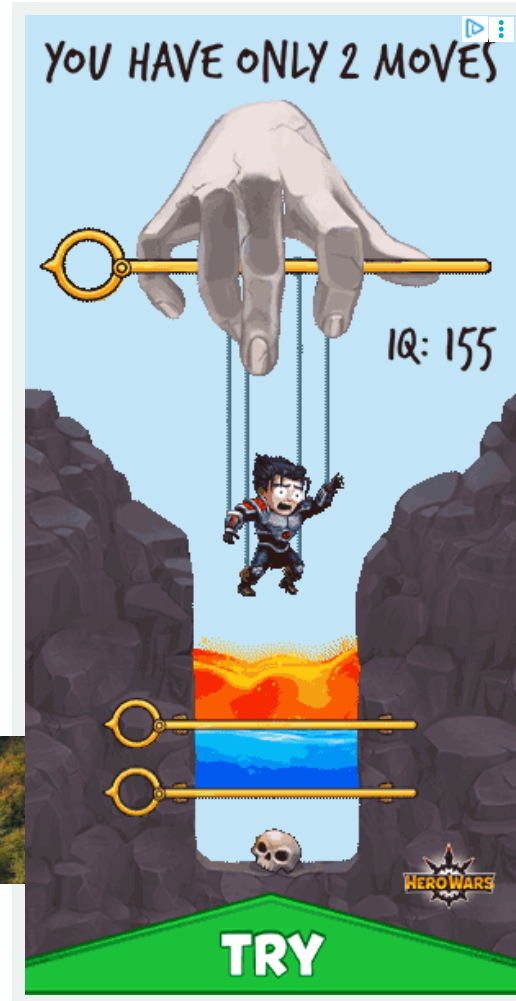
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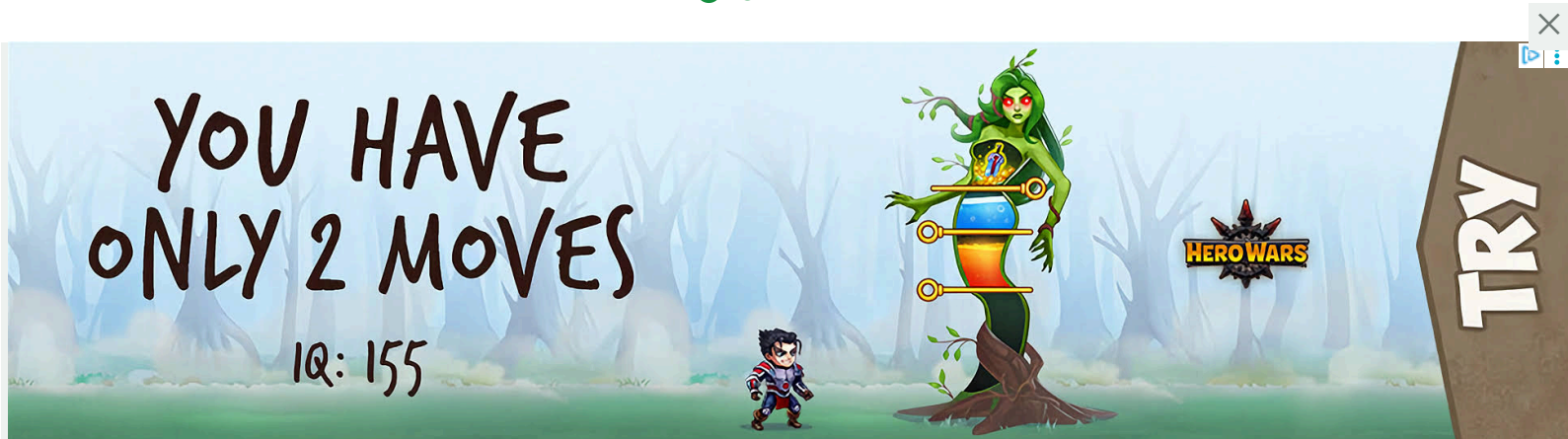
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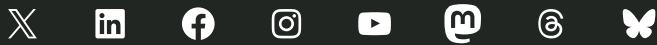
Aria Alamalhodaiei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the public utilities and the power grid for California Energy...

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